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Building Your Brand

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As an accounting major, I chose the Ryan, LLC Property Tax Consulting Job Simulation. I wanted to become more familiar with companies like Ryan, LLC and accounting corporations. As a sophomore, I am largely unfamiliar with accounting companies and feel behind my peers. Since I am also freshly starting to take accounting courses, I do not know what I want to specialize in. The Ryan, LLC job simulation showed me a glimpse of tax consultation.

For the forage program, I stepped into the role of Ryan tax associate performing property tax tasks. The client, Paseo Hotels, was concerned they were overpaying property taxes on their Southwest Florida properties. In property tax consultation, my job was to make sure Paseo was paying the lowest amount of property taxes possible. As a consultant, you need to determine which method (income approach, sales comparison approach, cost approach) is the most appropriate.

The first tax I used was the sales comparison approach. I used the open market and third party to provide the best estimate of value for the Paseo property. Through the use of multiple Excel sheets, I calculated a fair market value of the Collier grand, Paseo Lee Resort, and Paseo Royal Palms. I started with the provided average sales price per room for three transactions. With each hotel, I multiplied the average sales price per room with the total number of rooms, including suites. Although basic multiplication, I was quite confused on the root of these transactions. Having only taken financial accounting, I am inexperienced in accounting specificities. This would have made more sense if I had taken this forage simulation in a year or two. Next, I used the Costar adjustment data (a provided percentage) and multiplied that to the sales method value. The adjustment data displayed the condition of the property. It gives you a list of data based on the room types and their sustainability, but does not have reasoning behind this. This is extra information. The job simulation also provided me with adjustments based on the property type. However, there was zero explanation for the reasons behind these adjustments for the different hotels. I assume it has to do with interest or outstanding factors, irrelevant to the basic tasks. I added or subtracted the adjustments to the conditional cost, creating the sales adjustment approach for the three properties.

Once completed, the job simulation explained I would review the findings with my client, Paseo hotels property tax department. I would compare Ryan LLC's findings to the previously assessed values. I would help compare and contrast the findings to conclude whether action needs to be taken, to help lower the real property tax.

Although the job simulation did not pursue the compare and contrast findings, I was able to determine one adjustment based on the provided answers. It would be helpful in the future, if this simulation could explain to me the process of comparing property tax values and why I completed the calculations. For example, the Paseo Collier Grand Hotel had a county assessed property tax value of 150,000,000 dollars. The adjusted value was only 122,684,881 dollars. Therefore, I could assume that my client, Paseo hotels, was paying significantly more in property taxes than needed. As a consultant in this simulation, I am doing Paseo Hotels a favor. However the simulation does not go over what would be required of me if the adjusted value was greater than the county assessed value.

The Ryan LLC job simulation had a second task of earning due diligence using the income capitalization approach. I worked with the Paseo hotel business development department to help

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acquire a boutique hotel. We assigned property value using the income capitalization approach. Once again, I was not given an explanation on why this approach was the right choice. If I completed this assignment further down the road, it might be common sense to why I would use this approach. The hotels business development department is in charge of improving the products, services, and operations of the hotels. They also evaluate potential acquisition candidates. In their desire to acquire a new boutique hotel, the Paseo development team obtained a pro forma income statement for the due diligence process.

The job simulation gives a warning to not go into the deep dives of the mechanics of this approach. The Excel sheet provided automatically calculates the results based on certain findings. If I should not do further research to understand the equations I am doing as an accountant, should this task be on an introductory job simulation? I believe it is counterproductive to showing me how to perform tax consultation jobs.

Nonetheless, the Excel sheet started with the gross property revenue, operating and department expenses, net income, replacement reserve, and capitalization rates. Valuation is determined by dividing the expected rate of return by the capitalization rate to reach a percentage. My task was started by studying the different assumptions and the approach. There is vertical analysis used in the income statement. As previously stated, they told me not to do further research. Their provided Excel sheet left me confused, and I had to study the sheet for more than the suggested time frame. Once again, I might be too inexperienced for this task. The main task asked by Ryan LLC was to complete 5 multiple choice questions about the valuation of the boutique hotel. In a client situation, I would not be completing questions but instead would review the model with the Paseo business development team to discuss a fair purchase price.

Ultimately, the multiple choice questions were basic multiplication/division questions and analysis on these equations. I understood how I was determining the purchase price for an acquisition hotel. However, this job simulation lacked crucial information to understand my role in this task. I was left in the dark about the roots of the income capitalization approach and reasonings behind many adjustments.

As an inspiring accountant, I am thrilled to have worked with due diligence and tax consultation. Working from within a real company like Ryan, LLC was an opportunity to see what real tax tasks are like. As a new student, I would like to revisit my job simulation after further advancement in my program. I believe I am worthy of the certification. I completed the tasks to my best ability, but not without confusion. It was incredibly useful for real world experience in understanding the job of a property tax consultant. In introductory accounting courses, professors normally avoid going into detail about tasks of different departments.

The Ryan, LLC job simulation gave me legitimate experience and introduced me into the tax consultant world, a job I knew nothing about. I am proud of my execution and time management. The job simulation did take longer than stated, but it was a good simulation to get started with. Hopefully in the future I can take more introductory courses that make me familiar with different fields in the accounting world.

As my first time using forage or completing a job simulation, I am looking forward to continuing my research. With a wide variety of options, I am going to take future simulations in different accounting departments to make the most use of my time and continuous effort.